

STAGE TWO • PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY & PERSONAL BRAND

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 40 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Two • Professional Identity & Personal Brand

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Two, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Two is the largest single stage in the program: forty FIRSTS across six sections. Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt, organized into the same six sessions used across this stage's other facilitator resources: Personal Professional Identity, Personal Brand Foundations, Digital Presence & Online Identity, Professional Communication, Professional Visibility, and Professional Materials.

Given the volume, expect each session to run longer than a typical Stage One session — roughly six to eight FIRSTS per session rather than six total. Suggested times are for framing and discussion only; independent worksheet time is scheduled separately in the companion Session Plan.

SESSION 1

Personal Professional Identity

Covers *FIRSTS B1-B6*

FIRST B1

Professional Introduction

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver a natural, timed 3-part introduction (under 60 seconds) they've said out loud and recorded once.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The first ten seconds of an introduction shape credibility more than anything said afterward — this is worth taking seriously, not treating as small talk.
- A rehearsed structure (not a memorized script) frees up mental space to actually sound natural rather than robotic.
- Recording yourself is uncomfortable but reveals timing and tone issues invisible from the inside.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Memorizing a script word-for-word, which reads as stiff and falls apart the moment someone asks a follow-up question.
 - Listing every class, club, and activity instead of a focused, memorable story.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B2

Elevator Pitch

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft two pitch versions (one for a recruiter, one for an academic context) and practice both aloud.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Real opportunities appear in short, unplanned windows — a chance encounter, not a scheduled interview. Without a ready pitch, the window closes before you can use it.
- A pitch needs a natural close or ask, not just a self-summary that trails off.
- Different audiences (a recruiter vs. a professor) genuinely warrant different framing, not the same pitch delivered twice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Making the pitch entirely about yourself with no natural close or ask.
 - Using one generic version for every audience instead of adapting to who's actually listening.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B3

Personal Brand Statement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft one clear brand-statement sentence and test it by having someone else paraphrase it back.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a clear statement, your resume, LinkedIn, and conversations tend to drift and contradict each other.
- One sharp sentence beats five vague ones — resist the urge to pack in every skill.
- The real test isn't whether it sounds good to you, it's whether someone else can accurately repeat back what you do.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing something so broad it could apply to almost anyone in the room.
- Trying to fit every skill and interest into one sentence instead of picking a clear angle.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B4

Professional Communication Style

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite three of their own recent real emails using a clear greeting/purpose/ask/closing structure.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Communication style is often judged faster than actual competence — a capable person with sloppy emails can be quietly overlooked.
- The goal is clarity, not formality for its own sake; overcorrecting into stiff jargon is just as much a problem as being too casual.
- Structure (greeting, purpose, ask, closing) does most of the real work — tone matters less than most people assume.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing emails too casually for a professional context out of habit.
- Overcorrecting into unnaturally stiff, jargon-heavy language that reads as trying too hard.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B5

Professional Confidence Mindset

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific low-stakes situation this week to practice showing up with more confidence.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Confidence, more than raw qualifications, often determines who gets remembered after an interview or networking moment.
- Confidence is a practiced behavior, not a fixed trait — it's built through repeated low-stakes reps, not willed into existence.
- This connects directly to the Public Speaking Recording (B26) and Video Introduction (B27) later in this stage — the discomfort doesn't fully disappear, but tolerance for it grows.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Confusing genuine confidence with overconfidence, or dismissing real feedback as a threat to it.
 - Avoiding practice opportunities specifically because they feel uncomfortable, which guarantees the discomfort never fades.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B6

Personal Value Statement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write one value statement using the “I bring / which helped / achieve” pattern, grounded in a real outcome.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- “I’m a hard worker” and “I’m a team player” differentiate no one — nearly every candidate claims the same traits.
- A statement grounded in a specific, provable outcome gives an employer something concrete to actually remember.
- This closes out the section by turning everything from B1–B5 into one evidence-backed sentence.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Staying abstract (“I’m hardworking”) instead of naming a real, specific, provable outcome.
 - Choosing an achievement that sounds impressive but isn't genuinely theirs to claim credit for.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 2

Personal Brand Foundations

Covers *FIRSTS* B7-B12

FIRST B7

Personal Brand Strategy

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants name three words they want associated with their name and one specific monthly action reinforcing each.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a strategy, professional identity forms passively — shaped by whoever happens to interact with you, not by your own intention.
- The three words need to be genuinely true, not aspirational fiction — a hollow brand collapses under scrutiny.
- This sets up everything through B12; a real strategy, not just a vibe, is what the rest of this section builds on.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing themes that sound impressive but don't actually match real strengths or interests.
 - Treating this as a one-time branding exercise rather than something reinforced through ongoing action.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B8

Personal Brand Positioning

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a positioning statement (“I’m the [role] who focuses on [specific intersection]”) and test it on someone unfamiliar with their work.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most candidates in a competitive field share similar coursework and credentials — positioning is what makes you memorable rather than “qualified but generic.”
- The sweet spot is specific enough to differentiate, broad enough to still be relevant to real opportunities.
- Testing it on a stranger (not a friend who already knows the context) is the actual test — friends are too generous.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Positioning too narrowly around a trend that may fade before it pays off.
- Staying so broad the positioning fails to differentiate at all.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B9

Professional Reputation Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants ask one trusted person how they'd describe them in three words, and reflect honestly on the answer.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Reputation forms whether or not you're paying attention — by the time a negative pattern is noticed, it may already be shaping opportunities.
- The value is entirely in the honesty of the answer — asking only people who'll flatter you defeats the purpose.
- Curiosity, not defensiveness, is the right response to an uncomfortable answer.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only asking people who will say what you want to hear.
- Getting defensive rather than curious when feedback is uncomfortable.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min (plus time to ask someone before the next check-in)

FIRST B10

Professional Image Audit

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants compare their current professional appearance against three real LinkedIn profiles in their target field and name one adjustment.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Image is one of the fastest signals people use to judge competence and fit, often before a single word is exchanged.
- There's no single universal standard — target-field norms genuinely vary, which is why comparing against real examples matters more than generic advice.
- Behavioral signals (punctuality, follow-through) count as much as visual ones — don't let this become purely about clothing or photos.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming one universal professional standard applies across every industry.
- Over-investing in visual appearance while neglecting behavioral credibility signals.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B11

Credibility Signals

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants replace vague language in their next three commitments with specific deadlines, and follow through without being reminded.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Credibility is built or eroded in small moments: following up when you said you would, being specific rather than vague, matching behavior to stated values.
- Overpromising to sound impressive in the moment does more damage than never promising at all.
- This is genuinely testable this week, not just theoretical — push participants to identify three real, current commitments.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Overpromising to sound impressive, then under-delivering.
- Treating vague language (“soon,” “I’ll try”) as equivalent to a real commitment.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST B12

Professional Boundaries

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one overloaded commitment and draft a respectful message proposing a specific adjustment.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Never setting boundaries makes someone known as easy to overload, not more valuable — this often produces burnout and less respect, not more.
- A boundary stated well, calmly and specifically, actually increases professional credibility rather than damaging it.
- This closes the section: brand strategy, positioning, reputation, image, and credibility all mean little without the ability to protect your own capacity.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting boundaries so aggressively they read as inflexibility.
- Avoiding boundaries entirely out of fear of seeming difficult or unhelpful.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 3

Digital Presence & Online Identity

Covers *FIRSTS B13–B20*

FIRST B13

LinkedIn Profile

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete at least one currently blank or outdated section of their LinkedIn profile during the session.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- LinkedIn is often the first place a recruiter or connection looks after meeting you — a weak profile undercuts every other networking effort.
- Copying resume bullets verbatim doesn't work; LinkedIn format and tone genuinely differ from a resume.
- Progress today should be real and completed, not just planned — have people actually edit their profile live.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving the profile half-finished indefinitely, assuming it's not that visible.
- Copying resume bullet points verbatim without adapting them to LinkedIn's format.

SUGGESTED TIME: *25 min (hands-on editing time)*

FIRST B14

LinkedIn Headline Strategy

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite their headline using the pattern: role, specific focus, and value or outcome.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The headline is the single most visible piece of LinkedIn text — it appears in every search result and every comment you make.
- “Student at University” wastes that visibility completely.
- Specificity beats keyword-stuffing; a genuine, focused headline reads better than one crammed with unrelated terms trying to game search.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Stuffing the headline with unrelated keywords to try to game search visibility.
- Leaving the LinkedIn default title with zero customization.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST B15

Professional Bio

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a 3-sentence third-person bio, opening with their brand statement from B3.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A polished bio prevents a rushed, inconsistent version each time one is requested — conference programs, guest speaker intros, portfolio sites.
- A bio needs a throughline, not just a list of activities strung together.
- This directly reuses the brand statement from B3 — if that's not solid yet, this exercise will reveal it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing a bio that's just a list of activities with no connecting throughline.
- Making it so long that no one reads past the first sentence.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B16

Digital Footprint Audit

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants search their own full name in an incognito browser and review everything on the first two pages of results.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most employers now search candidates online before or after an interview — old content from a different context can resurface and outweigh a strong resume.
- Privacy settings alone aren't enough; what's actually publicly indexed matters, which is why the incognito search is the real test.
- This is a recurring habit, not a one-time task — flag that explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming privacy settings alone are sufficient without checking what's actually publicly indexed.
- Auditing once and never revisiting it as new content accumulates over time.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B17

Personal Website

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants create a homepage with their name, brand statement, and contact information using a no-code site builder.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A personal website signals initiative and gives more room to showcase depth than LinkedIn or a resume allow.
- Especially valuable in creative, technical, or entrepreneurial fields — less critical, though still useful, elsewhere.
- Start minimal; an unfinished elaborate site is worse than a simple, complete one.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-engineering the site with unnecessary complexity before ever publishing anything.
- Launching it and then never updating it as new projects accumulate.

SUGGESTED TIME: *25 min (hands-on build time)*

FIRST B18

Professional Portfolio

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a 4-sentence case study (problem, role, process, outcome) for their single strongest project.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A resume tells an employer what you claim to have done; a portfolio shows them — especially decisive in creative, technical, and project-based fields.
- Context matters as much as the output itself: what was the actual problem, and what was genuinely your role in solving it.
- One well-documented project beats five thin, context-free ones.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Including too many projects without genuine context for any of them.
- Presenting only the final output without explaining actual role and process.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST B19

Professional Headshot

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants take five headshot options using natural light and select their strongest one to update across profiles.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The photo is often the very first thing noticed on a LinkedIn profile — a weak one undercuts an otherwise strong profile before anyone reads a word.
- Natural window light solves most amateur-photo problems instantly, no equipment required.
- Cropped group photos are a genuinely common and avoidable mistake — flag this explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using a cropped group photo instead of a genuine individual headshot.
- Choosing an overly casual setting that doesn't match target-industry norms.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min (including actual photo-taking)*

FIRST B20

Branding Color Scheme & Logo (Optional)

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

For relevant fields, participants choose two brand colors and apply them to one existing document, such as a resume header.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Explicitly optional — genuinely most relevant to creative, design, and entrepreneurial paths, not a universal requirement.
- A consistent visual identity signals professionalism and design sensibility before anyone reviews actual work.
- Keep scope tight: two colors applied to one document, not a full brand system built from scratch today.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-investing time in visual branding at the expense of actual portfolio content.
- Choosing a look that doesn't match target-industry norms just because it's personally appealing.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min (optional, skip for non-visual fields)*

SESSION 4

Professional Communication

Covers *FIRSTS B21-B27*

FIRST B21

Professional Email Style

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite their next real email using a clear subject line, two-sentence purpose, and one specific ask.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Email is often the first and most frequent written communication a professor or recruiter receives from you — it forms an impression before any relationship exists.
- Burying the actual request several paragraphs in is a common, easily fixed mistake.
- This should be a real email being sent this week, not a hypothetical exercise.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping the subject line or leaving it vague.
- Burying the actual ask deep in the email instead of stating it clearly and early.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B22

Professional Email Template

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft one reusable template for the email type they send most often, with clear personalization placeholders.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Writing every professional email from scratch is slow and risks forgetting a key element under time pressure.
- A template's value depends entirely on genuine personalization — an obviously copy-pasted message damages the relationship it's meant to build.
- This directly extends B21's structure into something reusable, not a separate skill.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a template without personalizing the placeholders, which reads as impersonal.
- Treating the template as a finished product rather than a starting structure to adapt each time.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B23

Meeting Presence

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare one specific question or contribution point before their next real meeting and commit to raising it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- How you show up in meetings shapes your reputation as much as your actual output, especially early in a career when work product is less visible.
- Both extremes are common failure modes: total silence (reads as disengagement) and dominating the conversation (leaves no room for others).
- Preparing one specific point in advance genuinely increases the odds of actually speaking up in the moment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Staying silent throughout a meeting, which reads as disengagement even if it isn't.
- Dominating the conversation without leaving space for others to contribute.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B24

Question-Asking Skill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare two specific, non-searchable questions before their next class, meeting, or interview.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Good questions are often remembered more than good answers — they signal genuine curiosity rather than rehearsed performance.
- A question easily answered by a quick search signals the opposite of genuine engagement.
- Preparation beats improvisation here; going in with two ready questions changes the odds of actually asking one.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking questions that are easily searchable online, signaling low effort.
- Asking so many questions in a row that it feels like an interrogation rather than a dialogue.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B25

Professional Listening Skill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice paraphrasing what someone else said at least once in their next real conversation before adding their own point.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people listen to respond, not to understand — this shows up as conversations that feel disjointed or self-focused.
- Genuine listening builds trust faster than almost any other communication skill.
- Paraphrasing forces actual processing, not just polite nodding while mentally drafting a reply.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Interrupting to share your own related story instead of finishing hearing theirs.
- Nodding along without actually processing what's being said.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B26

Public Speaking Recording

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants record themselves delivering their elevator pitch from B2, watch it back, and note one specific improvement.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people underestimate how many filler words or unclear transitions they use until they see themselves on video.
- The actual learning happens in the playback review — skipping that step wastes the whole exercise.
- This directly reuses the B2 pitch, closing a loop rather than starting a new task from scratch.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping the playback review entirely, which is where the actual learning happens.
- Recording once and assuming that alone constitutes sufficient practice.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B27

Video Introduction

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants record a 60-second video introduction in a well-lit space with a simple background, using their existing pitch script.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Video introductions are now a standard part of many internship and remote-role applications — having one ready prevents scrambling under deadline pressure.
- Visible script-reading is an easy, common giveaway that undercuts an otherwise strong introduction.
- This closes the section by combining B1's introduction, B2's pitch, and B26's on-camera practice into one finished asset.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Recording in poor lighting or a cluttered, distracting background.

- Reading visibly off a script instead of speaking naturally from a practiced structure.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 5

Professional Visibility

Covers *FIRSTS B28–B34*

FIRST B28

Thoughtful Social Media Presence

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants decide on one realistic weekly commitment for professional social media and complete it once this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Recruiters increasingly view public social profiles as part of an overall impression — an intentional presence can actively help, not just avoid harm.
- Sustainability matters more than ambition here; an unrealistic posting frequency abandoned after two weeks is worse than a modest, kept commitment.
- This sets the tone for the rest of the section, which builds up from small, sustainable actions.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Committing to an unsustainable posting frequency that quickly gets abandoned.
 - Posting content with no connection to any clear professional theme.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B29

LinkedIn Post Engagement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants follow five relevant professionals or organizations and leave one specific, thoughtful comment this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Engaging with others' content is lower-pressure than posting original content, and still builds real visibility.
- A thoughtful comment puts your name and insight in front of that person's entire network — genuinely valuable, not just busywork.
- “Great post!” adds nothing; push for a comment that reflects a real, specific reaction.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving generic, low-effort comments like “great post!” that add no real value.
 - Engaging so rarely that no visible pattern of visibility ever builds.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST B30

Professional Content Share

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants share one relevant article or post this week with two sentences explaining why it matters to them.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Sharing with genuine commentary demonstrates critical engagement with your field, not passive consumption.
- A share with zero commentary reads as low-effort; two genuine sentences change that completely.
- This is a natural next step up from B29's comment-only engagement.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sharing content with no commentary attached, which reads as low-effort.
- Sharing so frequently it becomes noise rather than genuine, considered insight.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST B31

Blog/Article Post

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants choose one specific lesson from the past semester and draft a rough outline for a 500-word post.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Original writing demonstrates a level of thinking and initiative that sharing others' content cannot.
- This is one of the most durable pieces of evidence you can point to in an interview or portfolio later.
- A narrow, specific topic beats a broad one that says nothing new — push participants toward genuine specificity.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing a topic so broad it doesn't say anything genuinely new.
- Over-polishing to the point where the piece loses its authentic voice.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST B32

Thought Leadership Series

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants outline 3–5 future post topics connected to their first piece's theme, with a realistic monthly publishing target.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A single post shows you can write; a series shows sustained expertise and genuine commitment to an area.
- Realistic pacing matters more than ambition — an abandoned series can look worse than never starting one.
- This directly builds on B31, extending one post into a genuine ongoing practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Committing to an unsustainable publishing frequency, then abandoning the series after one or two posts.
- Choosing follow-up topics disconnected from the original piece's theme.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B33

Industry Trend Report

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one current industry trend and find two credible sources discussing it as a starting point for their own analysis.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Employers value candidates who follow their industry proactively, beyond what's covered in coursework.
- The value is in genuine analysis, not summary — simply repeating one article's points adds nothing.
- Two credible sources, not one, is the minimum bar for a genuinely informed take.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Simply summarizing a single article without adding genuine personal analysis.
- Choosing a trend too broad or already outdated to feel current.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B34

Professional Conversation Starter

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare three specific conversation openers tied to their next professional event or its attendees.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many people avoid networking events specifically because they don't know how to start conversations beyond surface-level small talk.
- Openers tied to the specific event or attendees work far better than generic ones prepared in a vacuum.
- This closes the section by turning visibility (posting, sharing, commenting) into real, in-person connection.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying entirely on generic small talk with no specific hook.
- Preparing openers so scripted they can't adapt naturally to how the actual conversation unfolds.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 6

Professional Materials

Covers *FIRSTS B35–B40*

FIRST B35

Resume That Stands Out

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite two resume bullet points to match a specific real job listing's keywords and priorities.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a strong resume, even a highly talented candidate may never get noticed — most resumes are skimmed for six to ten seconds.
- A single generic resume sent to every posting underperforms a tailored one, even a lightly tailored one.
- Quantified achievements beat listed responsibilities every time — push for real numbers wherever genuinely available.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Submitting the same generic resume to every job posting regardless of fit.
- Listing responsibilities instead of quantified, specific achievements.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B36

Cover Letter That Works

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft an opening line connecting one specific, recent detail about a real company to their own story.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many candidates skip the cover letter or write one that just repeats the resume in paragraph form — missing a real opportunity to tell a story a bullet list can't.
- A specific, recent company detail signals genuine research, not a template blasted to fifty companies.
- The opening line is the highest-leverage sentence in the entire letter — worth spending real time on.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Restating the resume in paragraph form instead of telling a genuinely new story.
- Using a generic template with no specific reference to the actual company or role.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST B37

Business Card / Email Signature

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a professional email signature including name, program, expected graduation, and LinkedIn link.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A polished contact identity makes it easy for someone to remember and reach you after a conversation — its absence can lose a promising connection entirely.
- Simplicity wins; a signature cluttered with links and quotes undermines its own purpose.
- This is genuinely quick to complete in-session — have people actually set it up live, not just plan to later.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Cluttering an email signature with too many links, quotes, or icons.
- Relying on verbally repeating contact information instead of having something concrete to leave behind.

SUGGESTED TIME: *10 min (hands-on setup)*

FIRST B38

Portfolio/Project Showcase

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice a two-minute spoken walkthrough of their strongest project without looking at written notes.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Talking through your work clearly and confidently is a genuinely distinct skill from writing a strong case study — interviewers often ask for exactly this live.
- Reading from notes during a live presentation undercuts confidence even when the content itself is strong.
- This directly builds on B18's written case study, converting it into a spoken skill.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reading directly from written notes during a live presentation.
- Going too long without checking whether the listener actually wants more detail on a specific part.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST B39

Online Portfolio Review

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific question about their portfolio or resume and message a mentor or advisor requesting a short review.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- It's easy to become blind to your own portfolio's weaknesses after staring at it for weeks — outside feedback catches gaps that would otherwise surface for the first time in a real interview.
- A specific question (“does my project section order make sense?”) produces far more useful feedback than a vague “any thoughts?”
- Following up to show the feedback was actually applied matters as much as requesting it in the first place.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking for feedback too broadly, which tends to produce vague, unhelpful responses.
- Not following up to show the feedback was genuinely applied.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST B40

Digital Presence Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants review LinkedIn, resume, and other professional platforms side by side and note any inconsistency in photo, headline, or focus.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Inconsistent information across platforms, an outdated photo on one, a different focus statement on another, creates doubt and makes someone look less put-together than a fully aligned candidate.
- This is the capstone of the entire stage — it should pull together everything built across all forty FIRSTS into one coherent, cross-checked presence.
- Frame this explicitly as a recurring practice, not a one-time task — platforms drift out of sync again within months without a periodic check.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Updating one platform and assuming all others are automatically current.
- Treating this as a single one-time task rather than a recurring check.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*